suicides in Japan has fallen annually since 2009, and is down by a third from its peak in 2003, even though the country ranks second among industrialized nations in suicides.[17]

Again, such statistics of social strength tell only part of a far more complex story. Yet they can be adduced to support an argument that Japan has more successfully dealt with its myriad problems over the past quarter century than most observers have recognized. Whether Japan can continue to maintain its stability, social cohesion, and basic economic strength without opening up its borders, overturning some traditional social structures, and introducing an element of disruptiveness into its culture will be the great question of Japanese history over the next two generations. Yet even to ask such questions is to again presume a Western frame of reference.

Japan in the World, but Not of It?

A country as wealthy and socially stable as Japan might be expected to embrace an energetic, if not assertive, global role. On the other hand, its exclusionary nationalism may serve to dampen a wholehearted embrace of foreign adventurism. The tension between these two attitudes defines Japan's approach to the world. Above all, it is the benign regional environment in which Japan has existed, even thrived, since 1945 that has allowed it the leisure to debate such choices and not feel forced into one position or the other. Yet Japanese understand well the foreign challenges they face and their potential impact on Japan's security, and hence way of life.

Not that the Japanese aren't constantly questioning the level of their involvement in the world. "Do you think we should take in more Syrian refugees?" the head of one of Japan's leading cultural exchange organizations asked me in November 2015 in Tokyo. "It looks like we're not doing our part." I demurred, noting that Europe has yet to deal with problems the refugee flood may cause. Twenty-four hours later, the